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1. Own key, valid: The remaining bytes in the key are displayed.

2. Own key, expired: The key can only be used for decrypting.

3. Imported key, valid: Only the total key length is displayed.

4. Imported key expired: The owner doesn't use it any longer for encrypting, but it can still be used.

If the status or the segment information of a key is corrupted, it cannot be used any longer, and a warning is displayed in the properties window.

Auditing/logging should be done at each level by recording each and every minutest detail of the operations done by each client. Such log files can be mined for retrieving important information.

Security considerations

A few security considerations should be kept in mind before implementing the one-time crypto system. These are:

1. Every external connection is a security risk. There is always a possibility that others retrieve information from your computer through a network connection. This can be done by remote control, Trojan horses or spyware, sending your files, or capturing keystrokes or screenshots. Therefore a standalone computer is recommended to store your crypto utilities. If your computer is used by others, you must move your keys to a physically secure place.

2. The encryption keys, in this case one-time pads, are to be considered as secret as the plaintext message. Unwanted reproduction of pads must be physically prevented. Never store pads on a server or network-connected computer. When exporting a one-time pad, utmost care should be taken so that the data is not compromised or in the possibility to be compromised. Never exchange the pad through public systems like the Internet or electronic mail. It is preferred to handover the pads in person.

3. Once a pad is no longer in use, it must be deleted by both parties. Old, forgotten or lost pads can still be used to decrypt messages that were stored. Inform all persons that received a copy of a pad that the pad is no longer in use and must be deleted. One secure way to store exported pads is on a CD. After use, this CD can be destroyed.

4. One should use a separate key for each of the contacts. When distributing a key to several people, there is a chance that one can decrypt each other's messages and there is a greater risk of compromising the key. If one believes any of the keys is compromised or unlawfully copied, it should be notified immediately to all the users of that key, who should delete all these keys and the messages that were encrypted with this key.

5. Other persons' one-time-pads should be stored with the same care as your pads. ●

An MS and BE in computer science and engineering, the author is a member of Cryptology Research Society of India and Cryptographical Society of India. He is working as Scientist 'E' at ADRIN, Department of Space, government of India, Secunderabad